centres, such as the Progressive Students Collective or the Women's Collective that promote student political activism related to issues of social justice and rights. However, as this chapter illustrates, the extent of apathy or lack of political literacy is much more extensive among the younger generation.

The nature of student politics has historically been linked to political parties and state patronage, where religious and secular student groups use university campuses as spaces to fight ideological battles, often resulting in violence and death (Nasr 1992; Llyod 1999). Student political activism, especially in public sector universities in Pakistan, is closely linked to politics within the provincial or national arena, where the extent of patronage provided to any one group is dependent on which political party is in power. Officially, student union activism has been banned time and again by various governments,[3] but the implementation of this ban has been selective, again linked to the dominant governing political party. The power of certain student groups is evident in the control these groups have on not only students but also faculty and administration, all of whom, either through intimidation or through ideological affiliation to the parent political party, tend to side with one student group against the other (see Nasr 1992; Nelson 2009; Akhtar 2018). Nelson's research in particular highlights 'the *growing irrelevance* of 'politics' as we know it – in effect, politics as a pattern of contestation, conflict and (ultimately) compromise' (Nelson 2009, p. 94; emphasis in original). It is this 'growing irrelevance of politics' that this chapter explores, by examining the neglected narratives of students who are not members of student societies.

The chapter begins with an exploration of historically located student activists and their role in the Pakistan movement, followed by an evaluation of the place of student activists in the newly independent Pakistan. The first part focuses on important events linked to student activism on university campuses and its impact on larger provincial and national politics, highlighting a complex relationship of patronage, and resistance between the state and its student activists. The increasing use of violence by student groups within universities and the selective ban on union activities across the years are also explored, providing a context for the narratives of students who are not members of such organizations. The nature of such students' political activism is also problematic, where narratives of political awareness reveal a limited understanding of political literacy. This is especially important in light of the lawyers' movement against Musharraf and the emergence of the populist PTI, which claims to have the support of the 'youth of Pakistan'. The discussion illustrates how the student activist, once celebrated by the Quaid-i-Azam as 'an arsenal of Muslim India'